

Week 8 — The Plan (Capstone)

Goal: Ship it. Applications actually submitted, and a five-year plan in writing that is *yours* — built from seven weeks of your own research, your own math, and real conversations. Nobody can assign you a future; this week you write your own.

Part 1: Apply

Submit **at least 3 real applications** from your Week 3 list (refresh it first — postings from five weeks ago may be gone, and new ones will be up).

For each application:

- Tailor the resume’s skill words and the cover letter to the posting (Week 6 taught you how)
- Record it: company, title, date applied, contact if any, follow-up date
- **Follow up after ~1 week** if you hear nothing: short, polite email or call restating interest. Most applicants never do this; it visibly separates you.

Also do at least one of:

- Ask one Week 7 contact if they’d refer you or pass your resume along (referrals beat cold applications by a mile — this is why Week 7 came first)
- Register with one staffing agency that places in local manufacturing
- Book an actual appointment with a community college advisor or an apprenticeship program

Part 2: Capstone essay (1000–1500 words)

Prompt: *“My five-year plan.”*

This is the document you’ll reread at 20 and 23. Requirements:

1. **Where I’m going:** the role/credential you’re aiming at by ~23, and why — grounded in what you learned, citing your own earlier work (“my Week 4 spreadsheet showed...”, “the technician I interviewed said...”)
2. **The route:** job + education path, with the money math (what you’ll earn, what school costs, what reimbursement covers, what you’ll cover)
3. **The next 90 days:** specific and dated. Applications, follow-ups, advisor meetings, application windows, deadlines. Include your **first internship or co-op window**: the first term you’ll be eligible (enrolled), and the date those applications open — big-company summer internships open the previous August-October (see `resources/internships-and-coops.md`).
4. **Milestones:** what should be true at 6 months, 1 year, 2 years, 5 years — concrete enough that future-you can check them (e.g., “employed as a technician within 4 months,” “12 college credits by next summer”)

5. **Failure modes and answers:** the three most likely ways this plan goes sideways (no offers? class + work overload? interest fades?) and what you'll actually do in each case
6. **What I'd tell myself from eight weeks ago.** One honest paragraph.

Part 3: Present it

Present the plan out loud — 15 minutes, like a real review. You're not asking for permission; you're briefing your stakeholders. Take questions.

Done when

- ☐ 3+ applications submitted and logged, follow-up dates set
- ☐ One referral/agency/advisor action taken
- ☐ Capstone essay written
- ☐ Plan presented

After Week 8

The program ends; the plan doesn't. The tracker's application log keeps going until there's an offer. And the plan should get a 90-day review on the calendar — same format, 15 minutes: what happened, what's next.